

**COLOMBIA Forcibly displaced civilian communities sheltering in Buga and Tuluá,
department of Valle del Cauca
Displaced community leaders**

Paramilitary forces have threatened to attack an internally displaced community, whose members have sought refuge in Tuluá, if they do not leave immediately. In light of the authorities' continued failure to combat paramilitarism and to protect civilians in the region, Amnesty International believes the displaced community is in grave danger. The organization is particularly concerned for the safety of displaced community leaders, who have been accused of working for guerrilla groups.

Written death threats have circulated in the municipal capital of Tuluá in recent days. One leaflet was signed by the army-backed paramilitary group *Autodefensas Unidas de Colombia - Bloque Calima* (AUC), United Self-Defence Groups of Colombia - Calima Bloc. This ordered forcibly displaced people seeking refuge in Tuluá to return home immediately or at the latest before 15 September, and accused them of disturbing the order and tranquillity of the municipality: "*Ustedes deben regresar a sus parcelas de forma inmediata, sino lo hacen tomaremos acción militar contra los que no desocupen. Su último plazo es el 15 de septiembre*" ("You must return to your land immediately, if you do not we will take military action against those who do not leave. You have until 15 September"). Similar threats have reportedly been made against displaced people in Buga.

People from internally displaced communities are often considered to be guerrilla sympathizers or collaborators by the armed forces and their paramilitary allies. As a result, they often suffer serious human rights violations.

Since July 1999 Amnesty International has received numerous reports of army-backed paramilitary incursions in the department of Valle del Cauca. These paramilitary attacks have resulted in the killings of over 200 people and the forced displacement of several thousand people from the rural municipalities of Tuluá, Bugalagrande, Buga and neighbouring areas. Despite repeated international condemnation, continued paramilitary attacks (see UA 266/00; AMR 23/68/00; 5 September 2000) and a strong security force presence, no decisive action has been taken to confront and dismantle paramilitary groups in the region.

BACKGROUND INFORMATION

The issue of forced displacement has highlighted the human rights crisis in Colombia. Displaced communities have often been victim to serious human rights violations committed by the security forces and their paramilitary allies in an effort to silence such communities and to prevent them from bringing their plight to international attention.

Members of the Colombian army and security forces, and their paramilitary allies, commit serious human rights violations with virtual impunity. Over the past five years, several thousand civilians have been killed by paramilitary groups. The Colombian government suspended the constitutional legal base for the formation of paramilitary organizations and in 1989 issued directives to the armed forces to combat and disband such groups, yet they continue to operate with the support of the security forces in many areas of the country.

Similarly, guerrilla forces and armed opposition groups have committed serious violations of international humanitarian law, for example executing those they accuse of being security force or paramilitary collaborators and supporters. On occasion this has included members of forcibly displaced communities.

RECOMMENDED ACTION: Please send telegrams/telexes/faxes/express/airmail letters in Spanish or your own language:

- expressing concern for the safety of the displaced communities seeking refuge in Tuluá and Buga, and for the safety of other displaced communities in the department of Valle del Cauca and urging the authorities to take immediate and effective measures to guarantee their safety;
- calling for a full and impartial investigation into links between the security forces and paramilitary groups operating in the department of Valle del Cauca, urging that the results are made public, and that those responsible for supporting and participating in such groups are brought to justice;
- urging the authorities to take immediate and decisive action to combat and dismantle paramilitary groups, in line with repeated government commitments and United Nations recommendations.

APPEALS TO:

President of the Republic

Señor Presidente Andrés Pastrana Arango

Presidente de la República

Palacio de Nariño, Carrera 8 No.7-26, Santafé de Bogotá, Colombia

Fax: + 571 286 7434, + 571 287 7939, + 571 284 2186, + 571 289 3377 or + 571 337 1351

Salutation: Dear President / Excmo. Sr Presidente

Vice-President of the Republic

Señor Vicepresidente Gustavo Bell Lemus

Alto Consejero Presidencial para asuntos de Derechos Humanos y lucha Contra la Corrupción

Cra. 8 #7-26, Palacio de Nariño, Santafé de Bogotá, Colombia

Fax: + 571 337 1351

Salutation: Dear Vice-President / Excmo. Sr Vicepresidente

Minister of Defence

Dr. Luis Fernando Ramírez Acuña

Ministro de Defensa Nacional, Ministerio de Defensa Nacional

Avenida Eldorado CAN - Carrera 52, Santafé de Bogotá, Colombia

Telegram: Ministro de Defensa, Bogotá, Colombia

Telex: 42411 INPRE CO; 44561 CFAC CO

Fax: + 571 222 1874

Salutation: Dear Minister / Sr. Ministro

Governor of Valle del Cauca Department

Señor Juan Fernando Bonilla, Gobernador del Departamento de Valle del Cauca
Gobernación de Valle del Cauca

A.A. 8759, Santiago de Cali, Colombia

Telegram: Gobernador, Valle del Cauca, Colombia

Fax: + 572 885 8813

Salutation: Dear Governor / Sr. Gobernador

COPIES TO:

National Advocate for the People

Sr. Eduardo Cifuentes
Defensor del Pueblo, Defensoría del Pueblo
Calle 55, No. 10-32/46, Santafé de Bogotá, Colombia

UN High Commissioner for Refugees
Alto Comisionado de las Naciones Unidas para Refugiados (ACNUR)
Calle 114 No.9-01 Edificio Teleport Torre A Oficina 601
Santafé de Bogotá, Colombia

and to diplomatic representatives of Colombia accredited to your country.

Please also raise these concerns with your own government. Urge your government to publicly condemn the latest threats and to monitor the efforts of the Colombian government to ensure that these threats are fully investigated, those responsible are brought to justice and action is taken to combat paramilitary groups in the region.

PLEASE SEND APPEALS IMMEDIATELY. Check with the International Secretariat, or your section office, if sending appeals after 20 October 2000.